

Lead Scoring in the Wild: Why Most Models Bury Good Buyers

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Many lead-scoring systems score on the wrong signals, or worse, score on signals that do not survive contact with a real intake form. We document a common failure mode: a deterministic model keyed on question identifiers that never match the answers a rendered form actually submits, so every lead is scored as cold.

We argue for scoring that reads the substance of what a lead says, financing readiness, timeline, specificity of need, against the agent's live pipeline, rather than brittle field matching. We show how an AI-read score, held to a transparent rubric, ranks intent more faithfully than weighted-checkbox approaches.

The report includes a before/after on a real workspace whose strongest buyers were sitting at the bottom of the list, and the rubric we now use to keep a score defensible and explainable to the agent who relies on it.